



A FREE GUIDE FROM MN TO MAIN STREET

Rochester to Mouse House

The 2026 Family's Guide to
Stress-Free Disney Travel

Your local roadmap from Southeast MN to Orlando magic.

Flight trends, parking hacks, shuttle secrets, and more.

mntomainstreet.com/travel
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Why This Guide Exists

You've decided to take your family to Disney World. That's amazing. Seriously. But here's the part nobody warns you about: the hardest stretch of the whole trip isn't Space Mountain, it isn't the line at Be Our Guest, and it isn't even keeping your three-year-old awake for the fireworks.

It's the 90 minutes between your front door in Rochester and the gate at MSP.

That gap is where the stress lives. Do you fly out of RST or make the slog up Highway 52? Where do you park that won't cost you a second mortgage? Is there a shuttle, or are you bribing your neighbor with a bottle of wine and a promise? And once you land at MCO—wait, how do you even get to the resort now that Magical Express is gone?

This guide answers all of it. Not in a generic, "here are some tips!" kind of way. In a Rochester-specific, I-know-your-exact-pain-points kind of way. Because we live here too.

What's Inside: Airport comparison (RST vs. MSP), 2026 flight trends and pricing windows, the MSP parking strategy that saves \$150+, Orlando ground transport options, a Rochester-specific packing checklist, and a minute-by-minute travel day timeline.

Think of this as the guide your neighbor who's "done Disney six times" would email you—except we actually looked up the current prices.

SECTION 1

Two Airports, One Decision

Which is right for your family? Let's break this down honestly.

RST — Rochester International Airport

Here's what RST does better than any big airport: it doesn't stress you out. You park close. Security takes ten minutes on a bad day. The terminal is small enough that your four-year-old can't wander off into a food court labyrinth. For families with little kids, that calm is worth real money.

The catch? No nonstop flights to Orlando. You're connecting through Chicago O'Hare, Denver, or Dallas. That adds 2–3 hours to your travel day and means at least one layover with overtired kids. Tickets also tend to run \$50–\$100 more per person than a direct MSP flight.

Our take: RST is a valid option if you've got kids under 5, if anyone in your family has airport anxiety, or if your flight leaves before 7 AM and the thought of a 4 AM Highway 52 drive makes you want to cancel the whole trip. The sanity premium is real.

MSP — Minneapolis-St. Paul International

MSP is where the deals live. Sun Country alone runs 25+ nonstop flights to Orlando every week, with one-way fares starting around \$94. Delta, Frontier, and seasonal carriers fill out the schedule. Three hours and eighteen minutes, gate to gate, no stops. That's hard to beat.

The trade-off is the drive. From Rochester, you're looking at 75–90 minutes up Highway 52, depending on whether you hit construction south of Cannon Falls (you probably will). Then there's parking, the terminal shuttle, the bigger security lines—it adds up. But for a family of four saving \$200–\$400 on airfare? Yeah. It adds up the other way too.

Our take: MSP is the right call for most Rochester families. The nonstop flight options, the price savings, and the 3-hour door-to-Disney-resort math make it the default choice. The rest of this guide assumes you're flying out of MSP—but everything still applies if you're shuttling from RST and connecting.

The Middle Ground: Shuttle to MSP

Don't want to drive to MSP? Don't want to pay for airport parking? There's a third option, and it's honestly underrated.

Rochester Shuttle Service runs 14 daily roundtrips between Rochester and MSP—about \$35 per person one-way. They pick up right in town and drop at both terminals. **Groome Transportation** and **Land to Air Express** (which has been doing this for 30+ years) offer similar service. The beauty here: no parking to worry about, kids can nap on the ride, and you show up at MSP ready to go.

Book the earliest morning run if your flight is in the 8–10 AM window. And book in advance—these fill up during spring break and MEA week.

	RST	MSP (Drive)	MSP (Shuttle)
Drive Time	~10 min	75–90 min	Pick-up in Rochester
Nonstop to MCO?	No (connect)	Yes — multiple airlines	Yes — multiple airlines
Avg. RT Fare	\$350–\$500+	\$183–\$350	\$183–\$350 + shuttle
Parking Cost	\$8–12/day	\$12–\$36/day	None
Stress Level	Very low	Moderate	Low
Best For	Small kids, anxiety, early flights	Best fares, nonstop flights	No-drive, no-parking peace

SECTION 2

2026 Flight Trends: MSP to Orlando

Knowing when to book is half the battle. The other half is knowing when NOT to book—because the Minnesota school calendar drives MSP-to-Orlando pricing more than anything Disney does.

The Sun Country Sweet Spot

Sun Country is the Rochester family's best friend for Disney flights. They run 25+ nonstop flights per week from MSP to MCO, with one-way fares that start around \$94 and roundtrips from about \$183. The flight is 3 hours and 18 minutes. You board at Terminal 2 (Humphrey side), grab a coffee at the small but solid concession area, and you're in Orlando before lunch.

Here's the thing: Sun Country releases their seasonal routes and deals early. If you're planning a winter or spring break trip, start watching fares by August. Set a Google Flights alert for your dates and let the algorithm do the obsessing for you.

***Bag fee heads-up:** Sun Country's base fares don't include checked bags. For a family of four with Disney-level luggage, add \$60–\$120 roundtrip for bags. Still usually cheaper than Delta, but do the full math before you click "book."*

The Minnesota Calendar Trap

You know how Disney has "peak" and "off-peak" pricing for park tickets? Airfare from MSP has its own version—and it's driven almost entirely by the Minnesota school calendar. Three windows to watch:

MN Spring Break (mid-March): Prices from MSP to MCO spike 30–50% during this window. Every family in the state has the same idea. Book 6–8 months out or pay the tax.

MEA / Education Minnesota Break (mid-October): This is the one that catches people off guard. It's a Thursday–Friday break that most non-Minnesotans don't know about, but MSP–MCO fares know about it just fine. Same advice: book early.

Christmas / New Year's: Peak of peaks. Book 8–10 months out. Or—and this is the insider move—fly out December 26th or later. Post-Christmas fares drop fast, and Disney's holiday decorations stay up through early January. You get the magic without the markup.

The Off-Peak Windows (a.k.a. Your Best Deals)

If you've got any flexibility at all, these are the windows where your wallet thanks you:

Late January / Early February: Historically the cheapest time to fly MSP–MCO. Marathon Weekend (mid-January) bumps things briefly, but the rest of this stretch is wide open. Weather in Orlando is perfect—70s and dry. Crowds are low. This is the move.

Late April / Early May: After spring break, before summer. Fares settle, parks thin out, and you're looking at warm-but-not-brutal Orlando weather. Flower & Garden Festival at EPCOT is in full swing. Chef's kiss.

Early September: Right after Labor Day. Kids are back in school elsewhere, park hours are still extended, and fares from MSP drop. If you can swing a mid-week trip, this is a sleeper pick.

Airline Cheat Sheet: MSP to MCO

Airline	Type	Terminal	Avg. RT Fare	Notes
Sun Country	Budget nonstop	T2 (Humphrey)	\$183–\$300	Best value; bag fees apply
Delta	Full-service	T1 (Lindbergh)	\$250–\$450	Best loyalty program; pricier
Frontier	Ultra-low-cost	T1 (Lindbergh)	\$150–\$280	Cheap base; everything's extra
Spirit*	Ultra-low-cost	T2 (Humphrey)	\$140–\$260	*Check 2026 availability

SECTION 3

MSP Parking: The Smart Play

Let's talk about the thing that stresses Rochester families out almost as much as the flight itself: where to leave the car for a week without spending \$250. Good news. You've got options—and one of them is borderline genius.

Option 1: The Mall of America Strategy

This is the move. Hear me out.

Mall of America now offers long-term overnight parking at **\$12 per night**. They've set aside 900+ spaces on the 7th level of the East Side ramp specifically for travelers. You park, walk downstairs to the MOA transit station, hop on the Blue Line light rail, and you're at Terminal 1 or Terminal 2 in about 12 minutes. Trains run every 10–15 minutes on weekdays.

For a family driving up Highway 52 from Rochester, MOA is perfect. It's right off I-494—you hit it before you even get into the airport traffic mess on the 5/77 interchange. Park, ride, fly. Done.

***The math:** A 7-night Disney trip at MOA parking = **\$84**. The same week in MSP Terminal 1 ramps = **\$210–\$252**. That's \$126–\$168 saved. That's a table-service dinner at Be Our Guest for the whole family. You're welcome.*

***One honest caveat:** Don't bother with the MOA strategy if you've got more than two kids, four suitcases, and a double stroller. Wrangling all of that onto the light rail platform at 5:30 AM is a nightmare. In that case, skip to Option 2.*

Option 2: EZ Air Park

EZ Air Park sits about 4.7 miles from MSP and runs a free shuttle that gets you to the terminal in 7 minutes flat. Rates start at **\$12.95 per day**, and if you stay 7 days you get one day free—so a week-long trip runs you about \$78. Open 24/7, holidays included.

This is the better play for bigger families or anyone who just doesn't want to deal with light rail logistics. You pull in, a shuttle picks you up with your bags, and you're at the terminal door. Coming home, you call from baggage claim and they come get you. Simple.

Option 3: MSP On-Site Parking

Terminal 1 (Lindbergh) runs about **\$30/day**. Terminal 2 (Humphrey) is around **\$36/day**. It's the most convenient option—park, walk in, done. But for a 7-day trip, you're looking at \$210–\$252. That's real money.

When it makes sense: short trips (3–4 days), families with mobility concerns who need to minimize walking, or anyone who values zero logistics over saving \$100+. No judgment. Sometimes easy is worth it.

Parking at a Glance

Option	Daily Rate	7-Night Cost	To Terminal	Best For
MOA Ramp	\$12/night	~\$84	Blue Line, 12 min	Budget-savvy, small families
EZ Air Park	\$12.95/day	~\$78*	Free shuttle, 7 min	Big families, lots of luggage
MSP On-Site	\$30–\$36/day	\$210–\$252	Walk-in	Short trips, mobility needs

**EZ Air Park: stay 7 days, get 1 free. Prices as of early 2026—always confirm before you book.*

**Want a custom packing-to-parking plan for your family's trip?
Book a free 15-minute Disney planning call with MN to Main Street.
mntomainstreet.com/book**

SECTION 4

Orlando Ground Transportation

You've Landed at MCO. Now What?

If you haven't been to Disney since 2021 or earlier, you might be expecting that free Magical Express bus from the airport. Bad news: it's gone. Disney ended the complimentary service in 2022, and nothing free has replaced it. The good news? The options that exist now are honestly pretty solid—and for families, the math works out better than you'd think.

Mears Connect Driven by Sunshine

This is the default for most Disney families, and for good reason. Mears Connect and the Sunshine Flyer merged back in 2023 into one service: **Mears Connect Driven by Sunshine**. They're the only 24-hour shuttle running from both terminals at MCO to all Walt Disney World resorts.

Two tiers to know about. **Standard** is a shared ride—you'll stop at a few resorts along the way. It's the cheapest option and works fine if you're not in a rush. **Express** goes straight to your resort, no stops. Kids under 3 ride free on standard service. Both are wheelchair accessible and ADA-compliant.

Book through mearsconnect.com before your trip. Walk-ups are possible but pre-booking guarantees your spot and usually saves a few bucks.

Private Car / Town Car

Here's something most families don't realize: a private town car from MCO to Disney property often costs about the same as Mears Express when you're booking for a family of four. You get a driver holding a sign with your name, help with luggage, a clean SUV or van, and a direct ride to your resort lobby. No waiting at a shuttle corral. No stops.

For Rochester families—especially the Mayo Clinic crowd who are used to a certain travel standard—this is a VIP start to the vacation without a VIP price tag. Look at Mears private vehicles or Tiffany Towncar. Pre-book. Don't try to sort this out at the MCO curb.

Rental Car: Do You Actually Need One?

Short answer: probably not. If you're staying on Disney property and your whole trip is Disney parks, skip it. Disney's internal bus, monorail, Skyliner, and boat system gets you everywhere you need to go.

The rental makes sense if you're planning off-property meals (some of Orlando's best restaurants aren't on Disney property), day trips to Universal or Kennedy Space Center, or beach days on the coast. Just know that MCO's rental car center is a separate monorail ride from the terminal—budget an extra 30–45 minutes—and Disney resort parking runs \$15–\$25 per night on top of the rental.

Ride-Share (Uber / Lyft)

Uber and Lyft work fine from MCO. The pickup area is at Terminal C, Level 2. Expect \$25–\$60 depending on demand and vehicle size. An Uber XL fits a family of four with luggage comfortably.

The downside: surge pricing is real at MCO, especially when a bunch of flights land at the same time (late morning and early evening are the worst). If you land at 11 AM on a Saturday, that \$30 estimate might be \$55 by the time you get to the curb. Pre-booked options are more predictable.

MCO to Disney: Your Options

Option	Cost (Family of 4)	Travel Time	Comfort	Best For
Mears Standard	~\$60–\$80 RT	45–75 min	Good	Budget families
Mears Express	~\$100–\$160 RT	30–40 min	Great	Families wanting direct service
Private Car	~\$120–\$180 RT	25–35 min	Excellent	VIP feel, big families
Rental Car	\$40–\$70/day + parking	25–35 min	Flexible	Off-property plans
Uber/Lyft XL	\$50–\$120 RT	25–35 min	Variable	Flexibility, no pre-booking

SECTION 5

The Rochester Family's Travel Day Checklist

This isn't a Disney packing list. You can find a thousand of those online. This is about the first 90 minutes—getting from your house in Rochester to your seat on the plane without losing your mind or your kid's favorite stuffed animal.

For the Car (Rochester to MSP)

- Snacks and water bottles for the 75–90 minute drive up Highway 52
- Tablets charged, headphones packed (one set per kid—trust us)
- Parking reservation confirmation printed or screenshotted (MOA or EZ Air Park)
- If using Rochester Shuttle Service: pickup confirmation and address
- Cash or card for tolls/gas (there are no tolls, but gas up before you leave—stations near MSP are pricier)
- Address pre-loaded in GPS: MOA East Ramp or EZ Air Park, not "MSP Airport" (you're not going there directly)

For the Airport

- All boarding passes accessible (digital in Apple/Google Wallet, or printed backup)
- One kid-friendly carry-on bag per child with activities, snacks, and a lovey
- Stroller — gate-check it at the jet bridge (free on every airline)
- Plane snacks in a separate bag (MCO food options post-flight are overwhelming with tired kids)
- A change of clothes for each kid in carry-on (you're leaving 30-degree MN for 85-degree FL)
- Your own refillable water bottle (fill after security—MSP has bottle-fill stations everywhere)
- Noise-canceling headphones or earbuds for you (because you deserve 3 hours of peace on that plane)

For Orlando Arrival

- Ground transport confirmation (Mears Connect booking or private car reservation)
- My Disney Experience app installed with park tickets and resort reservation linked
- MagicBand+ charged if you bought one (or just use your phone)
- Resort confirmation number easily accessible (not buried in email)
- A lightweight layer for each person — MCO's air conditioning is genuinely aggressive
- Sunscreen and sunglasses in carry-on (not checked bag—you'll want them within an hour of landing)

Pro tip from a Rochester parent: Dress the kids in their Disney gear for the flight. It gets them hyped, makes them easy to spot in the terminal, and Cast Members at MCO will often give them extra attention. Plus, you'll want those airport photos.

SECTION 6

Your Travel Day: Minute by Minute

Here's what a real travel day looks like for a Rochester family using the MOA parking strategy and a Sun Country nonstop. Adjust the times to fit your flight, but the rhythm stays the same.

4:30 AM	Wake up. Final bag check. Coffee is not optional.
5:00 AM	Load the car, pull out of Rochester. Highway 52 is empty this early — enjoy it.
6:15 AM	Arrive at MOA East Ramp (7th level). Park. Grab bags. Head to the transit station.
6:30 AM	Board the Blue Line at Mall of America station.
6:42 AM	Arrive at Terminal 1 (Lindbergh) or stay on to Terminal 2 (Humphrey) for Sun Country.
7:00 AM	Through security. For families: TSA PreCheck is worth every penny. Get it before your trip.
7:15 AM	Breakfast at the terminal. Kids are excited. Let them pick their own airport treat. It's vacation.
8:30 AM	Board your Sun Country nonstop to MCO. Settle in. 3 hours 18 minutes to go.
11:48 AM	Touch down at MCO. Welcome to Florida — and you gained an hour (Eastern Time)!
12:15 PM	Board Mears Connect Driven by Sunshine (or meet your private car).
1:00 PM	Arrive at your Walt Disney World resort.
1:30 PM	Check in. Change into Florida clothes. Sunscreen everyone. Yes, even Dad.
2:00 PM	YOU'RE IN THE PARKS.

You left your driveway 8 hours ago — and 3 of those hours were sitting comfortably on a plane watching Moana 2. Not bad, Rochester. Not bad at all.

SECTION 7

The Cheat Sheet

This is the page you screenshot, print out, and stick on the fridge. Everything you need, one place.

When to Book What

Item	Book This Far Out	Why
Flights (peak dates)	6–8 months	Spring break and MEA spike hard
Flights (off-peak)	2–4 months	Deals appear closer in
MOA / EZ Air Parking	1–2 weeks	Rarely sells out, but confirm
Mears Connect	2–4 weeks	Guarantees your spot + saves \$
Private Car (MCO)	2–4 weeks	Popular services book up for holidays
Rochester Shuttle	1–2 weeks	Fills during school breaks

Key Numbers at a Glance

What	Cost / Detail
Sun Country MSP→MCO (one-way / RT)	From ~\$94 / ~\$183
MOA overnight parking	\$12/night (~\$84 for 7 nights)
EZ Air Park	\$12.95/day (7th day free)
MSP on-site parking (T1/T2)	\$30–\$36/day
Rochester Shuttle Service	~\$35/person one-way
Mears Connect (family of 4)	~\$60–\$80 RT (standard)
Disney resort parking	\$15–\$25/night
Flight time MSP→MCO	3 hrs 18 min nonstop

All prices as of early 2026. Always confirm current rates before booking.

Meet Your Planner



Officially Certified

Authorized Disney Vacation Planner
Walt Disney Travel Company

As a Rochester, MN local—born and raised in the Med City—I've spent over two decades mastering every corner of Walt Disney World, Disneyland, and Disney Cruise Line. Whether you're a first-timer loading up the minivan on Hwy 52 or a seasoned Disney vet planning your next anniversary cruise, I'll handle every detail so you can focus on the magic.

I know what it's like juggling Mayo Clinic schedules, Rochester Public Schools calendars, and trying to figure out the best week to fly out of RST or MSP. That's why I build custom itineraries around your family's real life—not a one-size-fits-all template from a national call center.

And if you're not ready for a full Disney vacation yet, there's plenty of Disney magic closer to home. In 2026, Rochester families can catch Disney on Ice at Target Center, Disney in Concert at Orchestra Hall, and the Worlds Collide Tour—all within easy driving distance up Hwy 52.

My planning services are completely free to you. As an Authorized Disney Vacation Planner, I'm compensated directly by the Walt Disney Travel Company. You get a local expert in your corner at zero cost.

Let's Make Your Disney Trip Effortless

You now know how to get from Rochester to the resort lobby without breaking the bank or your sanity. The fun part? Planning what happens when you get there.

Book a Free Disney Planning Call

We'll build a custom plan for your family — park strategy, dining reservations, and all the insider tricks that turn a good trip into a great one.

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Sources & Disclaimer

Prices, schedules, and services reflect publicly available information as of April 2026. Always confirm current rates directly with providers before booking.

Sun Country Airlines — suncountry.com

Rochester Shuttle Service — rochestershuttleservice.com

Groome Transportation — groometransportation.com

Mall of America Parking — mallofamerica.com/parking

EZ Air Park — ezairpark.com

MSP Airport Parking — mspairport.com/parking

Mears Connect — mearsconnect.com

Metro Transit Blue Line — metrotransit.org

My Disney Experience — disneyworld.disney.go.com

MN to Main Street — mntomainstreet.com

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